

THE CROSSROADS

09

**BOLLYWOOD'S
BROKEN LENS**

Aayush Sreenath

THE NATION REMEMBERS

The Editorial

PUDHU MANDAPAM

Adwaith Praveen Nair



THE CROSSROADS

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JULY, 2025

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The EDITORIAL

I still remember, as clearly as if it were yesterday, my first reaction upon being taken to the Little Hearts Centre as part of the Seva Week activities. I had heard and read about the challenges of healing mental health patients before; but seeing is believing, they say, and I can now add understanding to that. Suffice it to say my reaction was one of confusion, shock and distaste bordering on disgust. I remember thinking, “How could anyone ever heal these people?”

The answer, as Vaidehi Murarka of Grade 12 writes in her piece on the unequal access to mental health care, is vociferous and arises from unexpected quarters. Murarka’s account of the voices that present the sole beacon of hope to those from under-privileged communities who face mental health issues, is both instructive and inspiring.

From mental health heroes, we come to another category of healers - those who bandage the widening rift between man and nature. Valmik Thapar was one such sentinel of the wild, a passionate conservationist who dedicated his entire life to saving Bharat’s tigers. He left us on 31st May, aged 73. The poetic eulogy penned by Aniruddha Koganti of Grade 11 is a solemn hat tip to the great man himself.

Closer to home, this month of July has also been one buzzing with activity for us students. With MUN, TEDx, Science Expo, and inter-school sporting events following hard on each other’s heels, there was hardly a pause to even breathe. Reporting on two such events are Dhruvik Agarwal and Arnav Jain of Grade 12.

Another article that readers will surely appreciate is Aayush Sreenath’s (11) fine commentary on the decline of Bollywood. In it, he artfully presents a bird’s eye view of what Bollywood was and what it has become: an adda of complacent mediocrity, replete with overused tropes, and sustained by free-flowing money. Yet, the most important question, as Sreenath aptly poses, is whether Bollywood can recover its former genius. After all, anything and anybody can mend their ways. Just like my reaction when I was taken to the Naveen Rehab and De-Addiction Centre for another Seva activity. I still remember swallowing my pride and asking, “Hello, how are you today?”

Closer to home, this month of July has been one buzzing with activity for us students.

HIS STORY OF ITIHAAS

*The history textbooks teach us what is history.
But who wrote the textbooks?*

His Story of Itihaas is a true story loosely based on Neeraj Atri and Munieshwar Saagar's 'Brainwashed Republic', while also drawing heavily from writer-director Manpreet Singh Dharmi's personal experiences. At its heart, His Story of Itihaas unapologetically exposes the gaping inadequacies of our education system. Veteran Marathi actor Subodh Bhavé stars as the unimpeachable Namit Bharadwaj, a physics teacher who decides history is more his thing when he discovers what his daughter's history textbook really contains: fiction posing as fact. Opinions parading as authority. Selection masquerading as secularism. Shocked, Namit undertakes a journey to unearth the truth for himself.

He exemplifies a line from the film: "To get something out, you must go in." There are several beautiful scenes that have him surrounded by hundreds of books; as he reads voraciously, he reclaims his itihaas, fact by fact.

His Story of Itihaas also features the capable Yogendra Tikku, Ankur Vikal, Akanksha Pandey and Kisha Arora in supporting roles. They play a cocktail of characters - good, bad, even ugly - that impel or impede Namit's progress.



The film resonates at so many levels. For we see ourselves in one, or many, of the characters. Aren't we all guilty - at some time or the other - of letting our itihaas down? And that's what His Story of Itihaas gets spot on. The scenes, especially the ones that counter established historical narratives, are superbly researched and hit hard. The dialogues provoke thought and ask questions we have kept buried for too long. The film rattles, opens eyes, and stays with you long after the credits roll. Like good art always does,

His Story of Itihaas confronts us with a reality we must face: our education system is cracked. We ourselves have dug its gaping chasms, and continue to worsen the damage through our continued apathy and ignorance. The fact that there have been attempts to smother this film with just such an apathetic and ignorant silence simply worsens the matter.

For too long, too many of us have been taught to be ashamed of indigenous narratives but appreciative of Western ones. His Story of Itihaas goes against that grain. It roars, it replies, it reasons that Bharat's itihaas cannot be erased. Manipulated, distorted, suppressed and skewed, yes, but never erased. The hands that wield unmitigated power to asphyxiate the message of this film need to be told this in no uncertain terms. What we must do now in overwhelming numbers, is something all of us like very, very much: buy a ticket, grab some popcorn, and discover Your Story(ies) of Itihaas.

PUDHU MANDAPAM

ADWAITH PRAVEEN NAIR | IB I YEAR, CIRS

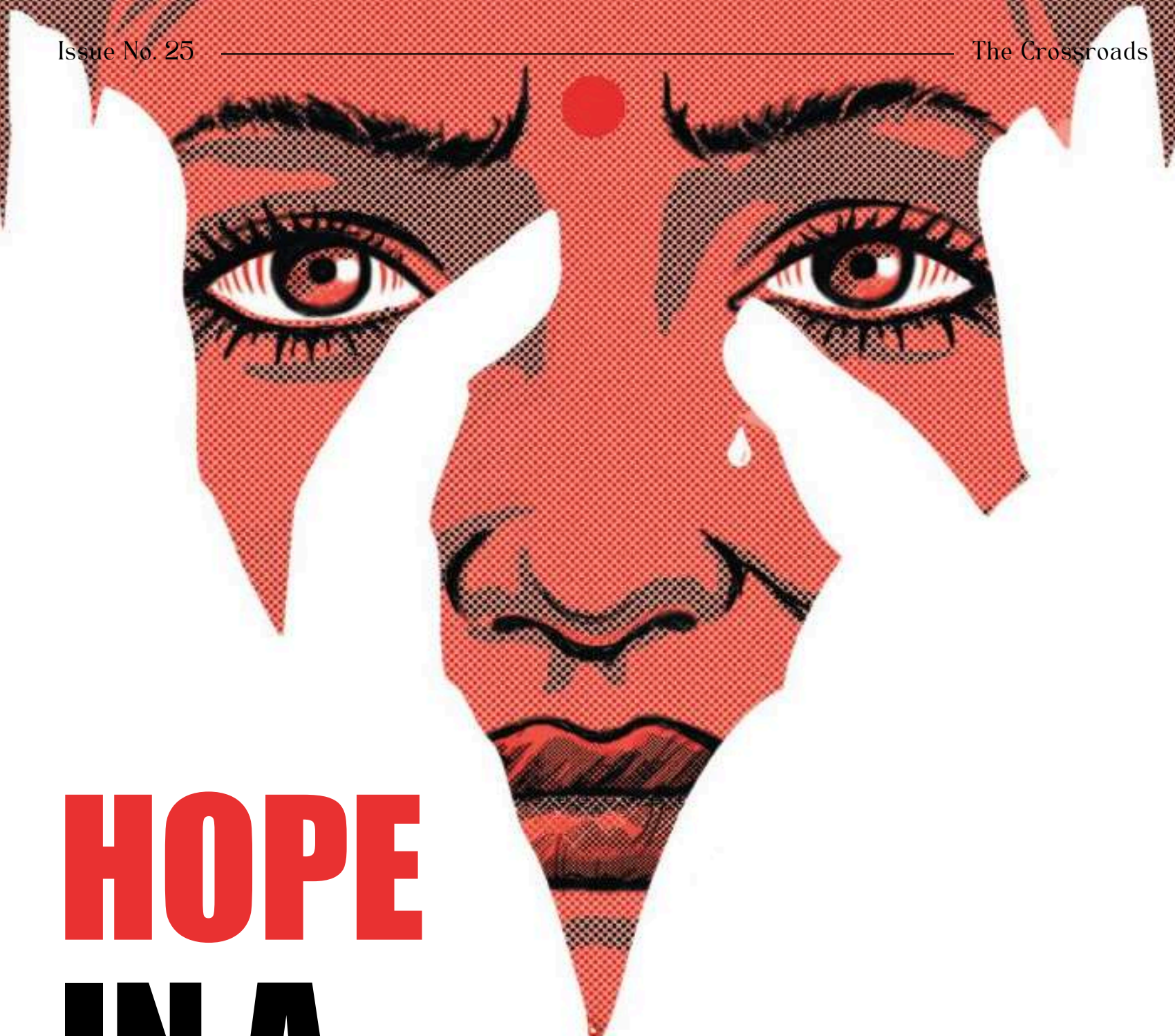
Most books tell stories with words alone. But Pudhu Mandapam tells tales through profound silence, moving emotion, and captivating photographs; it draws you in without saying much. What at first glance seems to be just another fancy collection of images from a quiet, forgotten corner of Madurai, slowly unfolds into an experience that touches you deep within. It makes you pause and truly appreciate the richness of Bharat's forgotten history.

Their voices span centuries, the mouthpiece of a civilization that continues to thrive even today.

Built in 1635 in the heart of Madurai, alongside the famous Meenakshi Temple, the Pudhu Mandapam was originally conceived as a ceremonial hall. Today, it lies decrepit and abandoned, ghosts of its illustrious past dormant amongst its ornate carvings. But as I flipped through the pages of the book, I saw more than just the stones and structures of a people lost to time; I was able to see their very lives, emotions, and stories. Whether real or surreal, I cannot say.

Looking at this book gave me a new take on history: sometimes, it can still live in the subtle textures of worn pillars in a ceremonial hall in Madurai. For the Pudhu Mandapam, and others like it, are not just relics of a dead past. Rather, they are living archives of memory, identity and culture that we must revere. Emanating from ancient stone, their voices span centuries, the mouthpiece of a civilization that continues to thrive even today.





HOPE IN A HARD PLACE

VAIDEHI MURARKA | IB II YEAR, CIRS

The 1999 film, *The Sixth Sense*, is more than just a psychological thriller. At its core, it tells a story about a profound connection between the healer and the healed. The movie follows a young boy, Cole Sear, who confesses to something unimaginable: seeing dead people! What is striking is how Dr. Malcolm Crowe, a child psychologist, reacts. He doesn't dismiss him, laugh, or make him feel inferior. Instead, he listens, stays, and tries to understand what Cole feels. Throughout the movie, Dr. Crowe doesn't exactly "fix" Cole; he walks beside him, helping him accept, embrace, and overcome his problems. Something like this, it seems surreal, right? Well, for those coming from underprivileged backgrounds, it's not only surreal, it's almost unheard of. Across the

world today, access to mental health care is largely unequal. Most psychologists, therapists, and doctors prefer to work with patients who can afford their typically expensive services. As a consequence, innumerable individuals in low-income communities struggle with mental illness on a daily basis, but remain unnoticed and neglected.

Still, however surreal it may seem, people like Dr. Crowe do exist. They give their all, not for fame, wealth, or recognition, but purely because of their belief that no one should suffer in silence. To millions of patients in need, these amazing mental health professionals represent a shining lighthouse of hope in a sea of silent apathy. They consistently go way beyond the call of duty to listen intently without any judgment and do their best to transform the lives of those who require a helping hand.

One of them is Dr. Nadine Burke Harris, a pediatrician and former Surgeon General of California. She is dedicated to changing the way our society responds to one of the most serious, expensive, and widespread public health crises of our time: Adverse Childhood Experiences (ACEs).

These are traumatic events that children suffer up to the age of 17 and include neglect, abuse, domestic violence, and so on. Dr. Harris says, "We need to stop asking 'what's wrong with you?' and start asking 'what happened to you?'" Simple yet profound words that don't just acknowledge what these children are going through, but also aid their healing process dramatically. Her work emphasizes how trauma is a major risk factor affecting the health of children. For her, healing is about acknowledging and exploring a person's complete range of experiences, not just what is visible on the surface.

Father Gregory Boyle is a Jesuit priest and the founder of Homeboy Industries. His organization serves individuals who are criminalized and forgotten, providing critical services to the thousands who walk through its doors every year seeking a better life. Many who grew up in neighbourhoods wherein violence was prevalent, and Father Boyle had witnessed the devastating impact it had had on them firsthand. In communities like these, mental health support is considered non-essential, so he, along with members of his parish, adopted what was considered radical at the time: treat gang members as humans.

"You stand with the demonized, so that the demonizing stops," Father Boyle writes. What makes his approach powerful isn't the service alone; it's the belief that healing comes from acknowledging one's innate goodness and worth, regardless of current circumstances or past actions. One beneficiary said, "Homeboy Industries gave me a place and a face. A place to call home. And they gave me a face, meaning I no longer feel the need to have a mask or a brick wall up, anymore. I can be vulnerable and accepting of the real me." Another former gang member described Father Boyle saying, "He never saw me as a problem to be fixed. He saw me as someone who mattered."

Similarly, in the heart of Kolkata, Anjali Mental Health Rights Organization (Anjali MHRO) is redefining what mental health care looks like for the underserved. The organization was founded by Ratnaboli Ray in 2001 and works with understaffed and underfunded public mental hospitals. However, Anjali approaches its mission with a perspective of justice rather than mere charity. They assist people who have been institutionalised through years of ineffectual treatment by re-establishing contact with their communities. Using methods such as legal empowerment, tenacious advocacy, and focused care, they

rebuild the patient's lost identity. One program, the Janamanas, has proved to be particularly transformational by reaching out to hundreds hailing from marginalized and deprived backgrounds. This organization not only spreads awareness but also seeks to challenge deep-rooted stigmas regarding mental health. Anjali MHRO doesn't just provide mental health reform, it makes it a way of life.

The work done by Dr. Harris, Father Boyle, and Anjali MHRO often goes unnoticed. But its reward is far greater than what any monetary remuneration can provide. The very lives of these individuals echo what Dr. Crowe embodies: consistently "being" for somebody, even though leaving is the easiest thing to do. What they all have in common is their vision that healing doesn't end with a diagnosis. For them and their patients, recovery begins with being noticed for the first time. Their stories are proof that we can combat mental health negligence, and we can be there to help those in need. Even though we cannot directly volunteer through such organisations just yet, simple things like a friendly "What's up?" or "How're you doing?" go a long way in showing that we care. And most of the time, that makes all the difference.

FROM FORK TO FINGERS

STUTI AGARWAL | IB 1 YEAR, CIRS

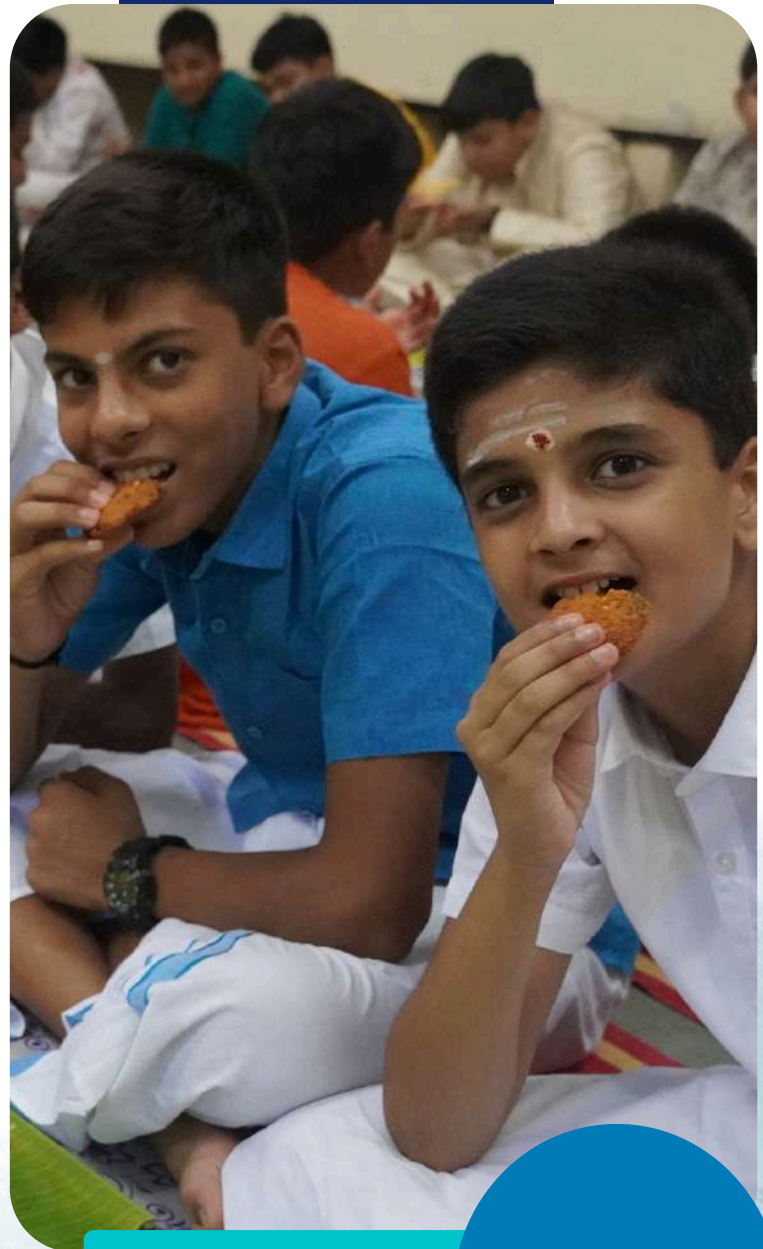
"Ewwww Papa!!!! Chee, why do you eat with your hands, especially in public? It's gross!"

These are the exact words I told my father every time he ate food with his hands. I found it unhygienic and strange and inexplicable. I mean, when you have a perfectly good spoon and fork, why eat with your hands? I just didn't get the point.

Things came to a head when one fine day, ten-year-old me was in the Annakshetra, sitting down for my first sadhya. We had to sit on the ground and eat using our hands from the banana leaf kept in front of us. This disgusted me. I wanted to just run and throw up. Looking at everybody around me eating with their hands made me feel terrible. I remember only eating a single puri, hurrying out, running back to the dorm, and repeating to myself: "I am NEVER doing that again!"

But life has a funny way of sending your way exactly what you dislike. And there I was again, sitting cross-legged, with a banana leaf in front of me for my third sadhya. And as usual, my friend's voice echoed again "Ek bar toh try karle, yar! You'll simply love it!" And for the first time I listened to her. My hesitant, awkward fingers skimmed the rice, and I took one-fourth of a bite into my mouth. Next, half a bite, and finally, a whole scoop. My face was twisted, eyes tightly shut; I felt like I couldn't even swallow.

To be continued...



Nritya TAALAM

AVIKA MUNDRA | IB 1 YEAR, CIRS

*Rhythm bounces off the walls
As anklets echo the tabla's call.*

*The music nestles the mighty beat
That nimble footsteps easily meet.*

*Mudras spread like powerful wings
Around the music of golden strings.*

*In the elegant flick of a wrist
Through the hands of the artist.*

*Not just mere passion or poise
But the entire world's joys.*

*This is the vibrant taalām of dance...
The eternal rhythm of poetry in motion.*



SHORTER THAN SHORT STORIES

It was at the National Youth Convention earlier this year that we were first introduced to the amazing concept of “Shorter Than Short Stories”. To elaborate, these are - obviously - very short stories open to a variety of diverse interpretations. They have no final explanation or understanding; what you take away from them is intrinsic and up to you.

Fascinated by this novel idea, we decided to attempt to write our own Shorter Than Short Stories. Published here are 2 of our humble attempts - an offering unto Gurudev.

The ceiling fans in the hall were rotating. One whispered, “Why do we keep spinning on and on and on without pause?” Another replied, “That’s what we were born to do.”

“Faster!”, shouted a third. “I come alive when I spin!”

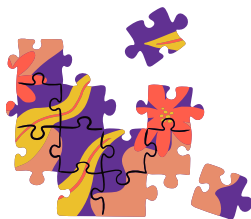
Suddenly, the current went out.

“Is this death?” asked a fan.

The paint bottles in an artist's box were fighting amongst themselves. Red said, "I'm the most energetic; I'm the best!" White screamed, "No, no, I'm the purest, I'm the best!" Yellow piped up, "But I'm the brightest, so I'm the best!" And so on.

The artist closed the box.

And the colors couldn't see anything anymore.



Velvet fur. Soft rose. Prickly grass. Smooth skin. Cold steel. Hard rock. Textures are all around us. They tell us how things feel, and help us make sense of the world. But how often - and how closely - do you observe the textures around you? To test yourself, read on. . .

Greetings Agent IO8. The 70 textures on this page have escaped from the objects they belong to. Your mission, should you choose to accept it, is simple: correctly identify where every texture has come from. Answers range from plastic to a wall to even a mango, so good luck catching them all! This message will not self-destruct in 5 seconds. Do not fail us!

Difficulty level: Ultra ■



BOLLYWOOD'S BROKEN LENS

AAYUSH SREENATH | IB I YEAR, CIRS

For decades, Bollywood reigned as the undisputed heart of Indian cinema—churning out hundreds of films each year, shaping fashion, music, and language, and setting the standard of entertainment for a billion people. From the lyrical romance of Raj Kapoor and Meena Kumari to the era-defining stardom of Shah Rukh Khan and Kajol, Bollywood wasn't just an industry—it was a cultural force. But in recent years, the shine has begun to wear off. Audiences are growing restless, critics are becoming louder, and beneath the veneer, a quiet truth is becoming harder to ignore: Bollywood is losing its charm.

There was a time when Bollywood wasn't just the face of Indian Cinema— it was Indian Cinema. It reflected the raw reality of the dreams, tragedies, humor and contradictions of the nation. But this once-thriving industry is now losing its loyal viewers, who are moving towards the more soulful cinema of the South. Are the successive big-budget, star-studded flops of Bollywood a sign of its inevitable decline, or is this just a transitional period that will lead back to its past glory? As this isn't the stale script of yet another Bollywood not-blockbuster, only time will tell.

But the thing is that this downfall isn't commercial—the box office numbers speak for themselves. The ruination we see in the Bollywood of today is artistic, cultural and ideological. Films have become increasingly hollow, recycled, and superficial. The novel storytelling that once carried heart and soul, has been replaced with cheap humor,

formulaic scripts, plastic glamour and a desperate clinging to outdated tropes. Nepotism continues to dominate casting decisions, while new voices and fresh talent are sidelined. Songs are remixed, dialogues are copied, and cinema is reduced to mere spectacle, often lacking authenticity or relevance. Movies like Zero, Thugs of Hindostan, Bombay Velvet and Adipurush focused on extensive VFX and costumes, but overlooked the quality of their stories, characters and emotions, which is the core reason for the recent downfall of Bollywood.

In contrast, there is another side to Bollywood. One that consistently resonates with rhythm, poetry and purpose. Emotionally grounded films like Barfi!, The Lunchbox and Kesari 2 were not over-the-top and did not

follow the generic sequence which most films did. Barfi!, for instance, was a whimsical yet poignant film about love, disability and acceptance. Without relying on bombast or gimmickry, it showed us a tender story of three imperfect people and their quietly magical world. The subtle performances and poetic cinematography brought out a beautiful message that silence can sometimes speak more than a thousand dialogues. Coming to The Lunchbox, a film that did not even focus on commercial advertisement, yet became a global phenomenon. It was about longing, loneliness and the quiet connection between two strangers in a bustling city.

There were no stars, no item numbers, no action scenes— just two people finding comfort in a lunchbox. It was cinema at its purest, instantly connecting with the emotions of the viewers. Small, honest, yet somehow unforgettable. All this time, far away from the big guns of Bollywood, an



BOLLYWOOD

unlikely star was being sculpted - regional cinema. Films made here have quietly but unquestionably stepped into the vacuum left by mainstream cinema. The Malayalam film industry, for instance, has become a powerhouse of storytelling rooted in realism and artistic courage. Kumbalangi Nights, Manjummel Boys, The Great Indian Kitchen, and Joji are films rooted in local culture but resonant with universal emotion. They prove that strong scripts, nuanced characters, and local stories can resonate not only across India, but globally.

Regional films embrace the texture of life, identity, and language, all with astonishing intimacy. The films are bold yet delicate in execution, often weaving together stories about caste, gender and politics, and at times also delivering powerful narratives about the true horrors of reality that most people are afraid to accept.

The important question, then, is not whether Indian Cinema is dying – it's about where it's truly living now.

If Pather Panchali was born today, it wouldn't be made in Mumbai, it would be made in Kerala or Tamil Nadu. And if The Lunchbox were pitched today, it would be lost in a pile of sequels and remakes. That is the tragedy of Bollywood: it has forgotten its own soulfulness. But the story does not end there. Cinema, much like our nation and her people, is always in flux. Maybe this is just a moment of reckoning – a pause before a revival. Perhaps one day, Bollywood will remember its roots, its beauty, and rise again. Until then, Indian cinema lives – and thrives – outside the City of Dreams, where the camera still captures life in its raw, unfiltered beauty.



ARNAV JAIN | 12 MGMT, CIRS

“Though there was such a huge generation gap, we never felt awkward interacting with them. The session was ever-engaging and interesting”, added Moksh Surana of Class 12. They even promised to return and conduct more such sessions for us. On the other hand, Neev Jain of Class 12 felt that he could have gotten more from the session had they delved deeper into career prospects related to accountancy. In conclusion, we would like to express our gratitude to our teacher, Dr. Rashmi P., for working tirelessly to give us this amazing opportunity. The knowledge that we have gained from this session has been invaluable in helping us connect more with the subject of accountancy.

It's not everyday that we get to meet somebody who taught our fathers. Neither do we often meet people who are shaping the future of millions across India. Yes; we, the students of Class 11 and 12 CBSE Management got the opportunity to interact with the real superstars of the accountancy world - Dr. (CA) G. S. Grewal and (CA) R. K. Khosla. The both of them have more years of experience than we have of age, and learning the nuances of accountancy from them was an unimaginable blessing.

The program kicked off with a soulful inauguration, followed by sessions for students of Classes 11 and 12. Naitik Agarwala, a student of Grade 11, described the session as “a dream come true. Meeting such eminent personalities helped me gain interest in the subject.” Overall, the session was very interactive and dynamic, with audience participation being at an all-time high. Be it the tough questions asked by Khosla sir or the patient clarifications provided by Grewal sir, everything contributed to increasing our concept clarity.



The Nation Remembers: 26 July, 1999

The Kargil War.
3 May, 1999 to 26 July, 1999.

527 Indian soldiers
killed.
1,363 wounded.

But.

Kargil was ours. Kargil
remained ours.

This is in remembrance
of those brave soldiers
who laid down their
lives to keep it that
way.

#KargilVijayDiwas.

MANOJ KUMAR PANDEY	MANOJ KUMAR PANDEY
YOGENDRA SINGH YADAV	YOGENDRA SINGH YADAV
SANJAY KUMAR	SANJAY KUMAR
VIKRAM BATRA	VIKRAM BATRA
VIVEK GUPTA	VIVEK GUPTA
PADMAPANI ACHARYA	PADMAPANI ACHARYA
NEIKEZHAKUO	NEIKEZHAKUO
KENGURUSE	KENGURUSE
DIGENDRA KUMAR	DIGENDRA KUMAR
RAJESH SINGH ADHIKARI	RAJESH SINGH ADHIKARI
BALWAN SINGH	BALWAN SINGH
ANUJ NAYYAR	ANUJ NAYYAR
CLIFFORD NONGRUM	CLIFFORD NONGRUM
SONAM WANGCHUK	SONAM WANGCHUK
MARIAPPAN SARAVANAN	MARIAPPAN SARAVANAN
AJAY SINGH JASROTIA	AJAY SINGH JASROTIA
JERRY PREM RAJ	JERRY PREM RAJ
SAURABH KALIA	SAURABH KALIA
VIJAYANT THAPAR	VIJAYANT THAPAR
MOHAMMAD FARID	VIJAY KUMAR MANI
VISHWANATH	VISHWANATH
SUB BALBIR SINGH	SUB BALBIR SINGH
GAUTAM GURUNG	GAUTAM GURUNG
ADITYA MISHRA	ADITYA MISHRA
KAUSHAL YADAV	KAUSHAL YADAV
SUCHA SINGH	K ASHULI
KRISHAN KUMAR BANDAR	KRISHAN KUMAR BANDAR
RANVEER SINGH BARALA	RANVEER SINGH BARALA
VINOD KUMAR NAGA	VINOD KUMAR NAGA
BIDYANAND SINGH	BIDYANAND SINGH
HARDEO PRASAD	HARDEO PRASAD
PRAMOD KUMAR	PRAMOD KUMAR
SHIVSHANKAR PRASAD	SHIVSHANKAR PRASAD
GUPTA	GUPTA
GANESH PRASAD YADAV	GANESH PRASAD YADAV
VIJAY SINGH	VIJAY SINGH
KISHAN LAL	KISHAN LAL
RAMPAL SINGH	RAMPAL SINGH
SUMER SINGH RATHORE	SUMER SINGH RATHORE
SURENDRA SINGH	SURENDRA SINGH
K ASHULI	SUCHA SINGH
SURJEET SINGH	SURJEET SINGH
RATTAN CHAND	RATTAN CHAND
JUGAL KISHORE	JUGAL KISHORE
DALER SINGH BAHU	DALER SINGH BAHU
VIJAY KUMAR MANKOTIA	MOHAMMAD FARID
MOHAMMAD ASLAM	MOHAMMAD ASLAM
HARENDRAGIRI	HARENDRAGIRI
GOSWAMY	GOSWAMY
DINESHBHAI	DINESHBHAI
SATPAL SINGH	SATPAL SINGH
SATBIR SINGH	SATBIR SINGH
JAGMAL SINGH	JAGMAL SINGH
BALDEV RAJ	BALDEV RAJ
JAI PRARASH SINGH	JAI PRARASH SINGH
MAHAVIR SINGH	MAHAVIR SINGH



MUN PHOTO

This photo essay has been compiled using submissions from the photographers of the International Press Corps. It is a testament to the finest standards of journalism they demonstrated over the course of the event. **#WeAreChaos**



The Delegate of Iran responds to an accusation during the DISEC crisis. The ferocity with which he defends his lost cause is plain to see, particularly as this was after his country was revealed to have orchestrated bombings across the world. **Photo by Shresth K.**



The Delegate of Iran from UNODC, gives a fiery reaction in UNWOMEN. Accusations flew and tempers flared as the committee raced to find a solution. **Photo by Malini K.**

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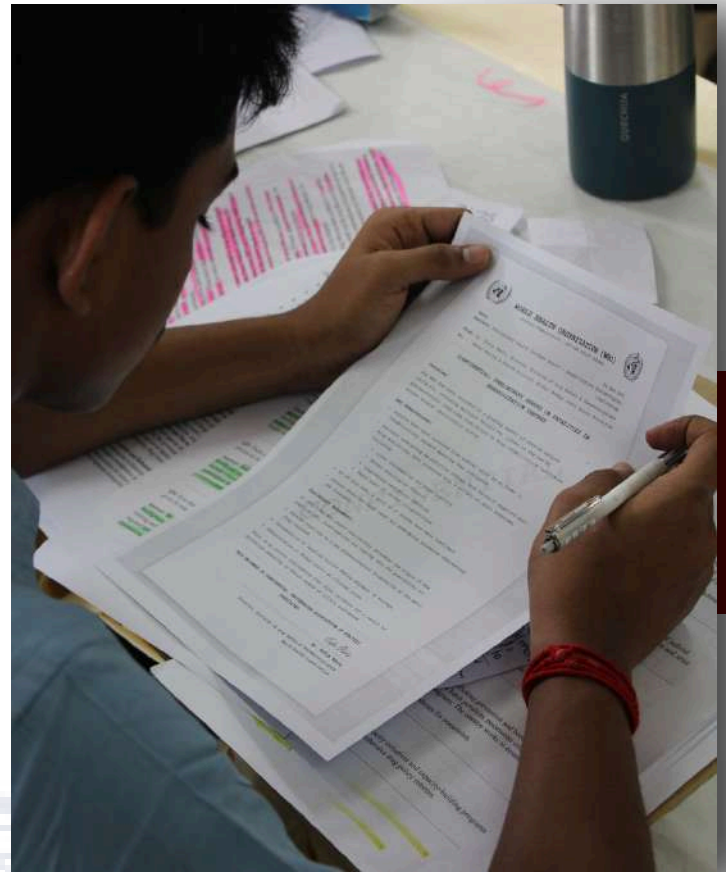
ESSAY

MUN MUN



Journalists of the International Press Corps in action during the DISEC committee session. Their relentless, point-blank questioning left delegates at a loss for words many a time during the 2 days of the conference.

Photo by Nehaa S.



A UNODC delegate reads the top secret Advisory from the World Health Organization (WHO) during the committee's crisis. This paper hit the Abolitionists' plans for victory hard by implicating them in an anti-WHO cover-up. **Photo by Sanjay S.**



The Delegate of the US reconsiders life choices after being taken captive on what was supposed to be only a "visit to the washroom". Upon being returned to the committee, he proceeded to tear into the countries responsible with a vengeance. **Photo by: Malini K.**

MUN MUN

SCIENCE EXPO'25

DHRUVIK AGARWAL | 12 MGMT, CIRS

It is a perennial complaint of school students that scientific concepts taught only from textbooks are theoretical, unclear, unrelatable, and as a consequence unimportant, or worse, useless. In such circumstances, any step, however small, goes a long way in bringing science out of the classroom's four walls and into the vast, fertile fields of the students' minds. The Science Expo conducted by Chinmaya International Residential School (CIRS) on the 25th of July was exactly such a step - just not so small.

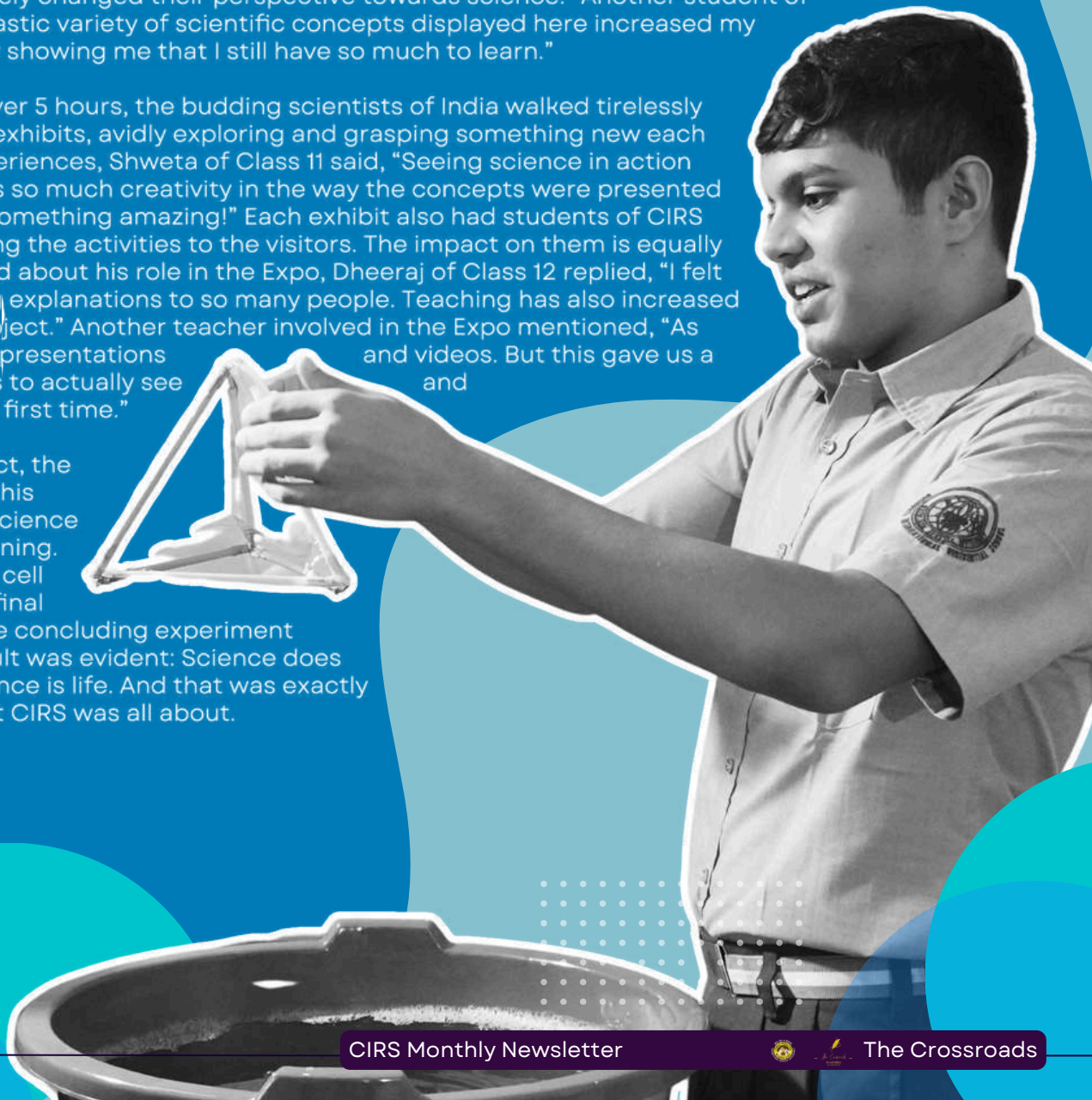
With over 135 hands-on, interactive experiments on display, the 900 students who visited the Expo had the time of their lives. They experimented and explored, hypothesized and applied, and upon stepping out, each had not just learnt science, but lived it. As Praneeth, a student of Class 10, put it, "The Expo taught me that science is way deeper than any textbook or syllabus. It enriched my practical knowledge by giving me insights into the 'how' beyond the 'what'."

To put things into perspective, Praneeth could not have encapsulated the Expo's objective more precisely: to observe, question, discover and celebrate science learning. To bridge the gaps that conventional classrooms cannot, and invest in our country's future by providing a platform for young scientific minds to collaborate and create without limits.

Quoting Sri. Satish, HOD of the Science department at CIRS, and one of the curators of the Expo, "Skill Development' and 'Hands-on Learning' are the primary goals of everything we have done here. This echoes the objectives of NEP as well. Translating textbook content into physical models has given the students a lot to think about and completely changed their perspective towards science." Another student of Class 8 added, "The fantastic variety of scientific concepts displayed here increased my interest in the subject by showing me that I still have so much to learn."

And learn they did. For over 5 hours, the budding scientists of India walked tirelessly across 2 entire floors of exhibits, avidly exploring and grasping something new each time. Describing her experiences, Shweta of Class 11 said, "Seeing science in action fascinates me. There was so much creativity in the way the concepts were presented in this Expo. And that is something amazing!" Each exhibit also had students of CIRS conducting and explaining the activities to the visitors. The impact on them is equally phenomenal. When asked about his role in the Expo, Dheeraj of Class 12 replied, "I felt confident after providing explanations to so many people. Teaching has also increased my knowledge of the subject." Another teacher involved in the Expo mentioned, "As teachers, we usually use presentations and videos. But this gave us a chance to allow students to actually see and even feel science for the first time."

And soon, too soon, in fact, the curtains were drawn on this unique convergence of science and the spirit of true learning. Ultimately, when the last cell had been observed, the final chemicals mixed, and the concluding experiment performed, only one result was evident: Science does not only explain life; Science is life. And that was exactly what the Science Expo at CIRS was all about.



THE TIGER'S DEAD

- In memory of Valmik Thapar

ANIRUDDHA KOGANTI | IB I YEAR, CIRS

Some men die, and the world forgets them. But only some. Others leave behind their legacies - not just engraved in stone, but instilled in the earth's very heartbeat. Valmik Thapar was one such man. He lived a life so untainted, so unflinching, so fiercely devoted to the wild, that the high and mighty of his times were forced to pay heed.

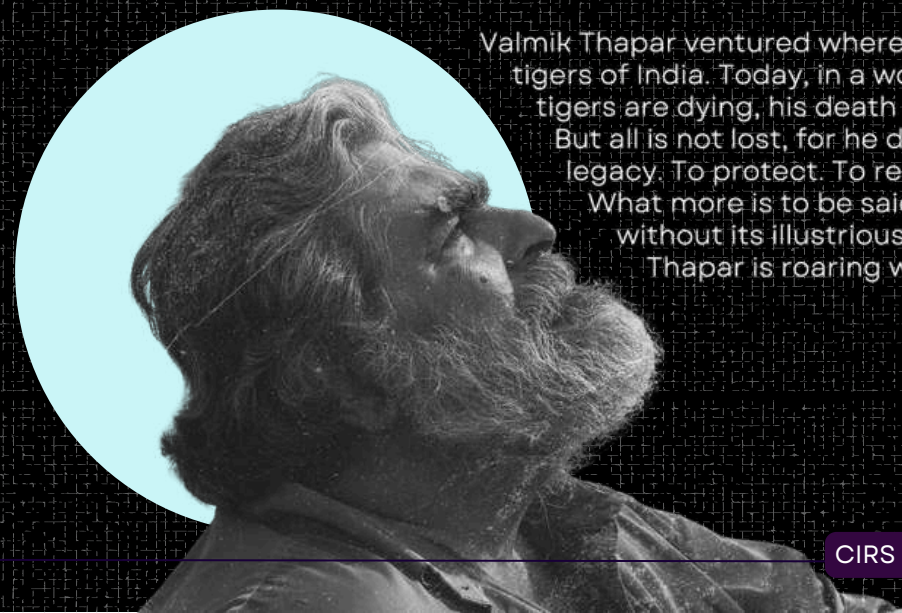
His sojourn did not start in the wilderness. He might have been born into privilege, but the jungle beckoned - and when the call of the wild came, it engulfed him in its entirety. It was a tiger named Machli who initially instructed him in the jungle's ways, and once that was done, Valmik belonged to the jungles of Bharat.

Valmik Thapar was more than just an activist, a raconteur. His was the voice that thundered the pain of the voiceless. Through more than 30 books and films, he awakened the world to the raw majesty of India's tigers. His words were not a passive plea for help - they were a passionate call to action for mankind to save what little they had left.

Every time the tigers needed him, Valmik was there. When all others succumbed to political pressure, Valmik roared defiance. His voice echoed in the corridors of power, protesting for better forest management, and dignity for the forest keepers who risk their lives in obscurity. In administration too, Valmik left his mark. He transformed the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) to provide autonomous control over tiger reserves. And established the Special Tiger Protection Force, a cadre trained to tackle poaching at the ground level. Valmik was also a pioneer in using camera traps and science-based monitoring in India, technology that has become the frontline of conservation efforts today.

Valmik Thapar ventured where few were willing to tread to save the tigers of India. Today, in a world where forests are shrinking and tigers are dying, his death feels like a gash upon the earth itself. But all is not lost, for he did leave us something. He left us his legacy. To protect. To remember. To fight.

What more is to be said? The jungle is now silent, empty without its illustrious son. Somewhere far away, Valmik Thapar is roaring with his tigers.

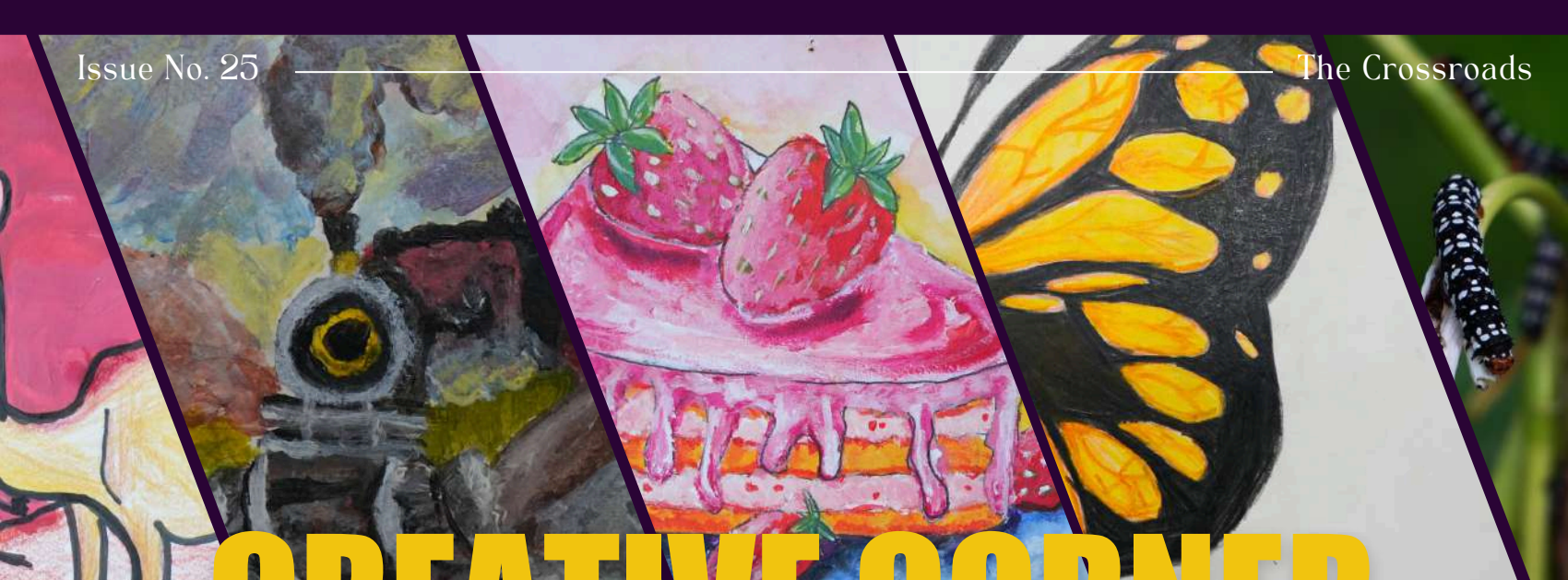




CAPTURES







CREATIVE CORNER



Yuvraj T. ~ IX 🎨



Anokhi K. ~ VIII 🎨



Kartik J. ~ VIII 🎨



Tarushi A. ~ XI 🎨



Vaidehi M. ~ IB II 🎨



Vihaan S. ~ VI 🎨



Nirvikalp ~ VIII 🎨



Jassvn K. G. ~ V 🎨



Eklayya A. ~ VIII 🎨



Chaitanya G. ~ X



Aryavardhan A. ~ VIII



Yuvika A. ~ VIII



Tanay L. ~ VII



Vedant A. ~ VII



Kanushree A. ~ XI

THE PRICE WE PAY

A cloud in the sky birthed by the ground,
A moment in which no noise was found.
A split second before mass destruction,
Skies torn apart, at man's instruction.

This was the fate of Hiroshima's people,
As the bomb blew away homes and steeples.
Though time has passed, the sorrow stays,
In haunted eyes and hollowed gaze.

Those who have suffered such devastating violence
Will always dread the foreboding silence -
Of freedom promised with fire, a lone flash,
And a bloodstained peace, marked by ash.

A fleeting choice, a fatal vice,
The world still mourns that sky-high price
Of lives shattered and dreams blown away,
Of cities erased in but a day;
That's the price we pay.





THE CROSSROADS

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Youth must look ahead; youth alone can dare to look ahead. The old will tend to look back and live in memories. The young is ever full of aspirations, hopes, plans to build a new world to fit in their demands in life. We must, in the wisdom gathered in the past, mould the present into the charm, beauty, shape and glory of a desirable future - Swami Chinmayananda

Our gratitude to the CIRS management for giving flight to our initiative.

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